

■ Thomas's ELA Mission Pack

Four real jobs · Grade 5–6 stretch · ~80 minutes · 50 points

Name: Thomas Huang **Date:** _____ **Time started:** _____ **Finished:** _____

Hey Thomas — this isn't a school test. No bubbles to fill in. You've got **four real jobs**: fix a newsroom mess, review a story, crack a case, and run a campaign. Do the jobs well and you'll show us what you're great at and what we should level up. Use your own brain, take risks on the hard parts, and **always back up what you say with proof from the text.** Let's go!

■■ Mission 1 — The Newsroom Fix-Up

Your role: You're the **editor** at a kids' science magazine. A new reporter sent in this article 15 minutes before it prints — and it's rough. Make it publishable.

HEADLINE: Octopus Facts

the octopus might be the strangest animal in the whole ocean. It has three hearts and blue blood, which sounds like something from a sci-fi movie. But the most amazing thing is it's brain. An octopus has nine brains — one main brain plus a tiny brain in each of it's eight arms. That means every arm can taste, touch, and make choices on it's own, even while the main brain is busy with something else. Octopuses are also experts at disguise they can change the color and texture of their skin in under a second to vanish from predators. The fastest land animal is the cheetah. In labs, octopuses have learned to open jars, escape tanks, solve mazes, and even recognize individual humans faces.

- 1A.** This reporter is sloppy with grammar and punctuation. **Find and fix at least 5 mistakes** — mark them on the text above or list them below (wrong version → your fix). [5 pts]
- 1B.** One sentence **does not belong** — it has nothing to do with the topic. Find it, and explain why a good editor would cut it. [3 pts]
- 1C.** "Octopus Facts" is boring. **Write a better headline** — accurate but catchy enough that someone actually clicks. [2 pts]
- 1D.** Pick **two dull or vague words** in the article and swap each for a stronger, more precise word (same meaning). [2 pts]

■ Mission 2 — The Story Reviewer

Your role: You run a popular **story-review channel**. Thousands of kids decide what to read based on you. Read the excerpt, then post your review.

From "The Open Mic" —

Priya had signed up for the talent show in a moment of brave stupidity, and she'd regretted it every day since. Her hands knew the guitar chords perfectly in her bedroom, where the only audience was a sleeping cat. But the cafeteria stage was a different country, one where her fingers turned to strangers.

The girl before her finished to a roar of applause. Then the host called her name, and the microphone waited like an open mouth.

Priya climbed the steps. The lights turned the crowd into a dark, breathing blur. She set her fingers on the strings — and froze. One second. Two. Somewhere a kid coughed.

She could run. The exit sign glowed red and kind at the back of the room, *promising*.

Instead, Priya did something she had never done in her bedroom: she looked up. She found one face — her little brother, Arun, in the front row, mouthing the words to a song he couldn't possibly know yet, just to make her smile. And she played. Not perfectly. Her voice cracked on the high note like ice on a pond. But she played all the way to the end, and when the last chord faded, the silence lasted exactly long enough for her to think *I did it* — before the room broke open with sound.

2A. Give it a **star rating (1–5)** and a one-line hook to grab readers. [\[warm-up\]](#)

2B. In your review, tell your followers **what this story is really about underneath the plot** (its theme), and point to the **moment everything turns** for Priya. Quote **at least two exact details** from the text as proof. [\[7 pts\]](#)

2C. Find **one example of figurative language** (a simile, metaphor, or strong image) and explain what feeling or idea it creates. [\[2 pts\]](#)

2D. End like a real reviewer: **who should read this story, and why?** Make it convincing. [\[3 pts\]](#)

■ Mission 3 — The Case File

Your role: You're a **detective**. Nobody will tell you what happened — figure it out from the evidence.

CASE #4408 — The Vanishing Science Project

When Mr. Ortega unlocked the classroom Monday morning, the prize-winning volcano model that had sat on the back counter all weekend was gone. Nothing else was missing.

The window was locked from the inside. The only key besides Mr. Ortega's belonged to the custodian, Ms. Lee, who had been visiting her sister in another city all weekend — a fact confirmed by three relatives.

On the counter where the volcano had stood, there was a faint ring of dried, reddish-brown liquid and a single crumb of what looked like a cracker. The classroom hamster, Nibbles, was unusually quiet, curled in the far corner of his cage. His water bottle was empty, though Mr. Ortega clearly remembered filling it Friday. And the latch on Nibbles's cage — normally secured — hung open.

3A. What really happened to the volcano model? Write your theory. (Hint: there's no human thief — think about the *whole* scene.) [4 pts]

3B. Prove it. List the clues that support your theory and explain how each one points to your conclusion. [3 pts]

3C. Two tricky words. Using only the clues around them, figure out what each means and **explain how you knew:** [4 pts]

- **"confirmed"** (confirmed by three relatives):
- **"secured"** (the latch, normally secured):

■ Mission 4 — Make Your Case (Campaign HQ)

Your role: You're running a **campaign**. The principal will read the most convincing argument and actually decide. Read **both fact sheets**, then write a pitch that uses evidence from **both** to win. This is the big one — plan first.

FACT SHEET A — School nurse: Kids aged 9–12 need 9–11 hours of sleep, but most get far less. The brain of a young person doesn't naturally feel sleepy until later at night, so waking at 6 a.m. for a 7:45 start means many students arrive exhausted. Tired students struggle to focus, remember less, and get sick more often.

FACT SHEET B — Transportation office: Buses are shared with the high school, which starts at 7:15. A later elementary start would need extra buses costing about \$90,000 a year. It would also push dismissal to 4:15, overlapping with parents' work hours and shortening time for after-school sports and clubs.

4A. Plan first (not scored — your scratch space). Pick your side: *Should school start later — yes or no?* Jot your claim + two strongest reasons.

Claim:

Reason 1:

Reason 2:

4B. Write your pitch — a strong paragraph (6–9 sentences) that: states your position clearly; uses **at least one fact from Sheet A AND one from Sheet B** (yes, even the one that argues against you); and ends with a line that makes the principal want to say yes. [15 pts]

■ Missions complete. Outstanding work, Thomas!